phenomenon. Sex ratios at birth are skewed starkly in favour of males due to a preference for sons and abortion of female foetuses. As it turns out, studies have shown that this cultural trait persists in Canada, even if it is under different material conditions.[39] Old habits often die hard in the diaspora.

## Oil and Toil: West Asia

The demographic rise of the six Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries —Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates, Oman, Bahrain, Qatar and Kuwait —from the 1970s is considered to be a major episode in global migration history. Immigrants now comprise half the population, more than three-fourths in some of the smaller states, in what has become the biggest destination for temporary migration in the world. Over seven million Indians work in the Gulf states, constituting a third of the foreign Asian workforce, a quarter of India's diaspora and half of India's current emigrant stock. Citizenship laws based on paternal jus sanguinis (right of blood) rule out permanent settlement and automatically create circulatory migration strategies that are male-dominated, even though Indian women, nurses in particular, dominate certain sectors. West Asia, or the Middle East, depending on your reference point, has therefore emerged as a major destination of the Great Indian Migration Wave.

The 'Gulf' is so strong in the Indian imagination that it is sometimes forgotten how and why India, and within India, the southern state of Kerala became an important part of its labour pipeline. Indian mercantile presence in the region, as recounted in earlier chapters, has a long history, as did the Haj pilgrimage routes, ferrying Muslims across the Arabian Sea, but labour migrations from India to the Gulf were relatively rarer. One exception to the rule was Aden in present-day Yemen, bordering the Gulf states, where the British ruled between 1839 and 1967. Until the 1930s, Aden was governed under the Bombay Presidency and hence hosted an Indian community estimated to be between 5000 and 10,000 people for a century.[40] Dhirubhai Ambani (1932–2002), founder of India's largest private company, Reliance